

Het Icon Veneration

het-icon-veneration

Heterodoxy Marker · Eastern Orthodoxy · doctrine · divided_lineages

DISPUTED

Supported across the whole Bible
Subject named directly in Scripture
No NT manuscript apparatus applies

Statement under examination

The honor due to God alone is not to be rendered to images of Christ, of saints, or of the cross; saints are not to be petitioned in prayer as mediators of access to God.

In plain language

The proposition has two parts. First, the honor owed to God should not be given to images of Christ, of saints, or of the cross. Second, saints should not be asked in prayer to serve as mediators of access to God. The clearest lexical evidence is the Ten Commandments. The Hebrew forbids making a carved cult image (pesel) and any likeness (temunah), and then forbids bowing to them (the verb shachah) and serving them (the verb abad). Deuteronomy 4:15 grounds the rule in a perceptual fact: at Horeb you saw no form (temunah), so do not make any. Isaiah 44:17 names exactly the proposition's two halves when it condemns the idol-maker who bows (sagad), worships (shachah), and prays (palal) to a carved image (pesel), three verbs stacked. In the New Testament, Jesus quotes Deuteronomy at Matthew 4:10 with two verbs and an adverb, you shall worship the Lord and serve him alone. The first verb is to worship or prostrate (proskuneo) and the second is to serve cultically (latreuo), and the adverb alone (monoi) binds both to God. Two scenes show a created being refusing prostration: Peter raises Cornelius saying he too is only a man (anthropos), and the angel forbids John and commands him to worship God. First Timothy 2:5 says there is one (heis) mediator (mesites), the man (anthropos) Christ Jesus. All of this leans toward the proposition. The reason the verdict is marked disputed is that the lexicon does not by itself rank every kind of relative honor. The Greek word to worship or prostrate (proskuneo) is used of creatures without condemnation, by the magi at Matthew 2:11, by the dying Jacob in Hebrews 11:21, and by the parable servant in Matthew 18:26. The Hebrew to bow (shachah) likewise covers Abraham's social bow in Genesis 23:7. The narrow cultic verb the canon does reserve for God is to serve cultically (latreuo), with its noun cultic service (latreia), and the Decalogue's paired verb to serve (abad). So the words distinguish reserved cultic service from broader prostration, but they do not by themselves decide whether a non-cultic relative honor toward an image of Christ falls under forbidden prostration or under permitted creaturely homage. Cherubim (keruvim) were made by divine command without bowing attached, and the bronze serpent was a sight-object until incense was offered to it and it was destroyed.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
H3742	כְּרוּב	keruv	cherub	
H3808	לֹא	lo	not	4,825
H5175	נָחָשׁ	nachash	serpent	
H5178	נְחֹשֶׁת	nechoshet	bronze	
H5180	נְחֹשְׁתָן	nechushtan	Nehushtan	

H5456	סָגַד	sagad	to prostrate	4
H5647	עָבַד	abad	to serve	290
H6419	פָּלַל	palal	to pray	84
H6459	פֶּסֶל	pesel	idol	31
H7812	שָׁחָה	shachah	to bow	163
H8544	תְּמוּנָה	temunah	likeness	10
G0444	ἄνθρωπος	anthropos	a human	567
G0846	αὐτός	autos	it/s/he	
G1520	εἷς	heis	one	367
G2316	θεός	theos	God	1,360
G2999	λατρεία	latreia	ministry	5
G3000	λατρεύω	latreuo	to minister	21
G3316	μεσίτης	mesites	mediator	6
G3441	μόνος	monos	alone	113
G4098	πίπτω	pipto	to collapse	90
G4352	προσκυνέω	proskuneo	to worship	60

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

The lexical core leans toward the proposition. The Decalogue (the Ten Commandments) forbids making a carved cult image (pesel) or a likeness (temunah) and forbids bowing down (the form shachah hishtaphel, that is, the reflexive prostration form of shachah) and serving (abad) such objects. Deuteronomy 4:15 grounds that prohibition explicitly in the absence of any seen likeness (temunah) at Horeb, and Isaiah 44:17 records the parallel idolatry triple of bowing (sagad), worshiping (shachah), and praying (palal), each directed at a carved image (pesel), which exactly mirrors the two halves of the proposition. Matthew 4:10 quotes Deuteronomy 6:13 with two verbs and an adverb, kurion ton theon sou proskyneseis kai auto mono latreuseis, meaning 'you shall worship (proskyneseis, future of proskuneo) the Lord your God and serve (latreuseis, future of latreuo) him alone (mono),' restricting both worship (proskuneo) and cultic service (latreuo) to God alone. Two New Testament scenes of refused prostration, Acts 10:25-26 and Revelation 22:8-9, show a created recipient refusing worship (proskynesis, the noun for prostration) and redirecting it to God. 1 Timothy 2:5 fixes a single mediator (mesites). The proposition is nonetheless marked disputed because the verb 'to worship or prostrate' (proskuneo) is documented across the canon for non-divine prostration (Matthew 18:26, Hebrews 11:21, the magi at Matthew 2:11) and the Hebrew 'to bow down' (shachah) likewise spans civil and cultic bowing (Genesis 23:7), so the lexicon distinguishes the two cultic verbs 'to serve cultically' (latreuo) and 'to serve' (abad) from the broader gesture verbs but does not by itself fix whether a non-cultic relative honor toward a Christian image of Christ or a saint falls under the prohibited acts or under permitted creaturely homage.

Scripture

Exod.20.4 · for · genre: law

Key terms. H6459 פסל; H8544 תמונה; H3808 לא

Reasoning. The clause prohibits making a carved cult image (pesel), together with any likeness (temunah) of what is in the heavens above, on the earth beneath, or in the waters below. The negation 'not' (lo) with the verb of making frames the object class broadly as fabricated cult representation.

Exod.20.5 · for · genre: law

Key terms. H7812 שחח, H5647 עבד, H3808 לא

Reasoning. Two negated verbs target the cultic response to such images: 'you shall not bow down to them' (lo tishtachaveh, you shall not prostrate yourself, which uses the reflexive prostration form, the hishtaphel, of 'to bow' (shachah)), and 'you shall not serve them' (lo taobdem, from the verb 'to serve' (abad)). The prohibition is on the directed act of prostration and service, not on the fabrication of an object as such.

Deut.5.8 · for · genre: law

Key terms. H6459 פסל; H8544 תמונה; H3808 לא

Reasoning. The Deuteronomic restatement repeats 'carved cult image' (pesel) and 'likeness' (temunah) verbatim with the same negation, a restatement pattern that confirms the prohibition across the law section rather than confining it to one pericope (one passage).

Deut.5.9 · for · genre: law

Key terms. H7812 שחח, H5647 עבד,

Reasoning. The parallel to Exodus 20:5, again pairing 'you shall not bow down' (lo tishtachaveh, the reflexive prostration form of 'to bow' (shachah)) with 'you shall not serve them' (lo taobdem, from 'to serve' (abad)), confirms that bowing and serving toward the image are the prohibited cultic acts.

Deut.4.15 · for · genre: law

Key terms. H8544 תמונה; H3808 לא

Reasoning. Moses grounds the prohibition in a perceptual fact: 'for you saw no form' (ki lo reitem kol temunah, where 'form' here is the same word likeness (temunah)), on the day Yahweh spoke from the midst of the fire at Horeb. The verse motivates the next verse's verb 'lest you act corruptly' (pen tashchitun) and make for yourselves a 'carved cult image' (pesel), a 'carved likeness of any figure' (temunat kol semel). The grammar ties the no-image rule to the absence of any seen divine form, not to a mere ban on craft.

Isa.44.17 · for · genre: prophecy

Key terms. H5456 סגד, H7812 שחח, H6419 פלל, H6459 פסל;

Reasoning. The prophet describes the idol-maker who takes the remainder of his wood and makes a carved cult image (pesel) of it, then 'bows to it and worships it and prays to it' (yisgad lo veyishtachu veyitpalel elav). Three verbs stack: bowing (sagad), worshipping (shachah), praying or petitioning (palal). The vocabulary maps directly onto the proposition's two halves, prostration before an image and addressing it in petitionary prayer, and condemns the combination.

Matt.4.10 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G4352 προσκυνέω, G3000 λατρεύω, G3441 μόνος, G2316 θεός

Reasoning. Jesus answers Satan citing Deuteronomy 6:13 in the Greek Old Testament (the Septuagint, abbreviated LXX) in expanded form: 'you shall worship the Lord your God and him alone shall you serve' (kurion ton theon sou proskyneseis kai auto mono latreuseis). Two future indicatives (ongoing or settled future statements of fact), 'you shall worship' (proskyneseis, from the verb to worship or prostrate, proskuneo) and 'you shall serve cultically' (latreuseis, from latreuo), are governed by the adverb 'alone' (monoi). The clause is the cleanest New Testament statement that the cultic gesture of worship (proskuneo) plus cultic service (latreuo) are jointly reserved to God, with the adverb foreclosing extension to any other recipient.

1Tim.2.5 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1520 εἷς, G3316 μεσίτης, G0444 ἄνθρωπος, G2316 θεός

Reasoning. 'For there is one God and one mediator between God and men, the man Christ Jesus' (heis gar theos, heis kai mesites theou kai anthropon, anthropos Christos Iesous). The numeral 'one' (heis) is predicative (functioning as the completing 'is one' element) and exclusive over the noun 'mediator' (mesites), framing a single channel of mediated access. The noun 'mediator' (mesites) occurs only six times in the canon and elsewhere is applied to Christ or to Moses as covenant mediator, never to a departed believer.

Acts.10.25 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. G4098 πίπτω, G4352 προσκυνέω

Reasoning. Cornelius, 'having fallen' (peson, an aorist participle, a completed past action, of the verb 'to fall' (pipto)) at Peter's feet, 'prostrated himself' (prosekunesen, aorist of the verb 'to worship or prostrate' (proskuneo)) toward him. The scene records prostration-worship (proskynesis, the noun form of proskuneo) directed at a created human recipient.

Acts.10.26 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. G0846 αὐτός, G0444 ἄνθρωπος

Reasoning. Peter raises him with 'stand up' (anastethi) and the explanatory 'I myself am also a man' (kai ego autos anthropos eimi, using the pronoun himself (autos) and the noun man (anthropos)). The created recipient refuses the directed prostration on the ground of his own creatureliness, redirecting honor away from himself.

Rev.22.8 · for · genre: apocalyptic

Key terms. G4098 πίπτω, G4352 προσκυνέω

Reasoning. 'I fell down to worship at the feet of the angel' (epesa proskunesai emprosthen ton podon tou angelou, using the aorist of 'to fall' (pipto) and the infinitive of 'to worship or prostrate' (proskuneo)). John fell to prostrate himself before the feet of the angel who was showing him these things. Again prostration-worship (proskynesis, the noun for prostration from proskuneo) is directed at a created being.

Rev.22.9 · for · genre: apocalyptic

Key terms. G4352 προσκυνέω, G2316 θεός

Reasoning. The angel forbids it with 'see that you do not' (hora me), names himself 'fellow servant' (syndoulos), and commands 'worship God' (to theo proskuneson, an aorist imperative, a command to perform a completed action, of the verb 'to worship or prostrate' (proskuneo)). The creaturely recipient refuses prostration-worship (proskynesis, the noun from proskuneo) and redirects it to God alone, a refusal pattern parallel to Acts 10:26 and a near verbatim doublet of Revelation 19:10.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Deut.5.8	Deut.4.15	tsk	1

Deut.5.9	Exod.20.4	tsk	1
Exod.20.5	Exod.34.14	tsk	1
Exod.20.5	Exod.23.24	tsk	1
Exod.20.4	Exod.32.1	tsk	1
1Tim.2.5	Job.9.33	tsk	1
Rev.22.9	Rev.19.10	tsk	1
Rev.22.9	Rev.4.10	tsk	1
Acts.10.25	Acts.14.11	tsk	1
Acts.10.26	Acts.14.14	tsk	1
Matt.4.10	Deut.6.13	tsk	1
Isa.44.17	Hab.2.18	openbible	1

Complicating texts

Matt.18.26 · addressed

The parable servant prostrates ('he was prostrating', prosekunei, an imperfect, ongoing or repeated past action, of the verb 'to worship or prostrate' (proskuneo)) before the king and the act is not condemned, showing that 'to worship or prostrate' (proskuneo) by itself denotes prostration that can be either divine worship or non-divine homage. This is resolved by noting that Matthew 4:10 pairs 'to worship or prostrate' (proskuneo) with 'to serve cultically' (latreuo) and the adverb 'alone' (mono) so that the lexical reservation to God runs through the combination of cultic verbs plus adverb, and that the Decalogue (the Ten Commandments) attaches its prohibition to the cultic 'carved cult image' (pesel) plus 'serving' (abad), not to the bare gesture of 'worshiping or prostrating' (proskuneo) or 'bowing' (shachah) in isolation.

Heb.11.21 · addressed

Jacob 'worshiped' (proskuneo) upon the head of his staff, citing Genesis 47:31. The verb describes the dying patriarch's reverent posture toward God, but the directional object is ambiguous between worship of God and a gesture made toward the staff as orienting object. This reinforces that the verb 'to worship or prostrate' (proskuneo) lexically does not by itself fix the recipient as God or as a creature, which is part of why the line drawn by the proposition is contested rather than lexically self-evident.

Gen.23.7 · addressed

Abraham bows (shachah hishtaphel, the reflexive prostration form of 'to bow' (shachah)) to the sons of Heth in a social courtesy that is not idolatry, demonstrating that the verb 'to bow' (shachah) spans cultic and civil prostration. This is resolved by observing that the Decalogue (the Ten Commandments) qualifies the prohibited bowing by its object, a 'carved cult image' (pesel) made as a cult image, and pairs it with the cultic verb 'to serve' (abad), so the verdict turns on the object class and on whether the act is cultic service rather than on the verb in isolation.

Matt.2.11 · addressed

The magi 'prostrated themselves' (prosekunesan, aorist, a completed past action, of 'to worship or prostrate' (proskuneo)) before the child with the bringing of gifts, an act that within the narrative is treated approvingly. Whether this is read as recognition of incarnate deity or as royal homage at a birth, the lexical observation is the same: 'to worship or prostrate' (proskuneo) by itself does not encode the cultic-worship reservation (the technical category called latria, after the verb latreuo), which is carried in this Gospel by the Matthew 4:10 pairing with 'to serve cultically' (latreuo) and 'alone' (mono).

1Tim.2.1 · addressed

The immediate context urges 'intercessions' (enteuxeis) made by living believers for one another, which shows that intercessory prayer among creatures exists. This is resolved against the petitioning of departed saints as mediators of access because 2:5 restricts the office of 'mediator' (mesites), the one who mediates access to God, to the one man Christ Jesus, distinct from mutual intercession among the living.

Exod.25.18 · addressed

The 'mercy seat' or atonement cover (kapporeth) bears two 'cherubim' (keruvim) of beaten gold by divine command at Exodus 25:18-20. The verbs that attach to the cherubim are 'covering' (sokak, covering with their wings) and 'making' (asah), not 'bowing' (shachah) or 'serving' (abad). The canon thus permits crafted images in cultic space when no bowing or service is directed at them, which is why the Decalogue prohibition is read as targeting directed cultic acts rather than craftsmanship as such. This is part of the lexical reason the doctrine's scope is contested.

Num.21.8 · addressed

The bronze serpent (nachash nechosheth) is made by divine command and lifted on a pole. The verb that attaches to the people is 'to look' (nabat), at Numbers 21:9, not 'to bow' (shachah). The image is a sight-object for healing, not a bow-object. 2 Kings 18:4 records that when later Israelites began burning incense to it ('burnings of incense', qittarim), it became 'Nehushtan' and was 'crushed' (kittath) by Hezekiah. The same item that was permitted as a look-object was destroyed once the cultic verbs attached. The shift from 'to look' (nabat) to incense is the lexical hinge: legitimacy of the image flipped exactly when prohibited cultic acts began to be directed at it.

Matt.4.10 · addressed

Jesus' answer to Satan is itself the lexical disambiguator: by pairing 'to worship or prostrate' (proskuneo) with 'to serve cultically' (latreuo) and binding both with the adverb 'alone' (monos), the dominical (the Lord's own) citation of Deuteronomy 6:13 ranks the two verbs together as joint-reserved to God. The verb 'to serve cultically' (latreuo) and its noun 'cultic service' (latreia), occurring 21 and 5 times respectively, are reserved across Hebrews, Romans, Acts, Luke, Matthew and Revelation for cultic service to God, never for honor to a creature. So the canon does mark a distinction between cultic worship-service that is reserved to God and prostration gestures that can be directed to creatures in non-cultic contexts, which gives the cultic-worship-reservation distinction (the so-called latria distinction) a real lexical foothold even though it does not by itself license image-veneration.

Concordance traversed

H6459, H8544, H7812, H5647, H5456, H6419, H3808, H5175, H5178A, H5180, H3742, G4352, G3000, G2999, G3441, G4098, G1520, G3316, G0444, G2316

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: n/a

The bundle reports 'not in ECM scope' (the critical edition of New Testament textual variants does not cover these verses) as true and supplies no variant units for the cited verses. The Decalogue (the Ten Commandments) anchors are Old Testament Hebrew outside CBGM scope (CBGM is the genealogical method used for the ECM apparatus, the critical edition of New Testament textual variants), and the cited New Testament verses lie outside the 3 John CBGM sample, so no published ECM apparatus (critical edition of New Testament textual variants) was examined. The verdict does not depend on any disputed reading.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. latria_dulia_distinction, covenant_theology, regulative_principle_of_worship

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

latria_dulia_distinction: disputed · This reading distinguishes worship (the category called latria, the cultic act named by the verb 'to serve cultically' (latreuo) and its noun 'cultic service' (latreia), which the canon reserves to

God by joint pairing in Matthew 4:10 with the adverb 'alone' (mono), from a lesser honor (the category called *dulia*, or relative veneration), directed through an image to its prototype. It observes that 'to worship or prostrate' (*proskuneo*) and 'to bow' (*shachah*) both span cultic and non-cultic uses, that Hebrews 11:21 and Matthew 18:26 and Matthew 2:11 use 'to worship or prostrate' (*proskuneo*) of creatures without condemnation, and that the canon does have legitimate image-craft in worship space such as the mercy seat (*kapporeth*) 'cherubim' (*keruvim*) and the bronze serpent before it became *Nehushtan*. On that lexical basis it treats the proposition as not lexically established because the line between cultic worship reserved to God and a permitted relative honor cannot be drawn from 'to worship or prostrate' (*proskuneo*) alone. The strongest form of this lens grants that the law forbids cultic prostration plus service to a 'carved cult image' (*pesel*) and grants that Revelation 22 and Acts 10 condemn prostration that crosses into cultic worship (*latría*, from *latreuo*), but holds that an image of Christ or a saint can carry an honor that is not cultic worship (*latría*) and therefore is not within the forbidden class.

plain_sense_decatalogue: affirms · This reading takes the negated 'carved cult image' (*pesel*) and 'likeness' (*temunah*) together with the paired prohibition on 'bowing' (*shachah*) and 'serving' (*abad*), as a single prohibition on directing cultic prostration toward any fabricated likeness. Deuteronomy 4:15 grounds the law in the absence of any seen 'likeness' (*temunah*) of God, and Isaiah 44:17 condemns the triple of 'bowing' (*sagad*), 'worshipping' (*shachah*), and 'praying' (*palal*), addressed to a 'carved cult image' (*pesel*), mirroring the proposition's two halves directly. The refusal pattern in Acts 10:26 and Revelation 22:9, in which a created recipient says 'I am a fellow servant, worship God,' and the dominical (the Lord's own) answer at Matthew 4:10 with 'to worship or prostrate' (*proskuneo*) and 'to serve cultically' (*latreuo*) bound by 'alone' (*mono*), are read as drawing the line in the same place: the directed cultic act, by whatever verb, belongs to God alone, and a relative veneration that involves bowing or petitionary prayer to a created representation collapses into the forbidden class.

The verdict turns on whether the Greek noun 'cultic service' (*latreia*) and the verb 'to serve cultically' (*latreuo*) carve out a narrow class of acts reserved to God that does not include image-directed 'worship or prostration' (*proskuneo*) when offered as relative honor, or whether the directed cultic act is forbidden under any verb when the recipient is a created representation. The lexicon distinguishes 'to serve cultically' (*latreuo*) as the more strictly cultic of the two main New Testament verbs, but it does not rank a non-cultic image-directed 'worship or prostration' (*proskuneo*) as either permitted or forbidden, which is the lexical seam the two lenses pull on. The Decalogue (the Ten Commandments) verbs 'to bow' (*shachah*) and 'to serve' (*abad*) also span semantic ranges, and Deuteronomy 4:15 grounds the no-image rule in the absence of a seen 'likeness' (*temunah*) rather than in a general ban on craft.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Examine whether the canon's lexical pattern distinguishes honor or prostration that may be directed toward images of Christ, saints, or the cross, and whether departed saints may be addressed in prayer as mediators of access to God.

The original stem embeds a verdict by asserting that honoring images is rendering the honor due to God alone and by asserting that saints are not to be petitioned. The neutralized form poses the same lexical question without presupposing the answer. The verdict was derived on the original stem.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Exod.20.4
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Exod.20.5
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Deut.5.8
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Deut.4.15
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Isa.44.17
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Num.21.8

morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	2Kgs.18.4
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H6459
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H7812
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H5456
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H6419
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G4352
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3000
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2999
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3316
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Matt.4.10
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Acts.10.26
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Rev.22.9
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Tim.2.5
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Exod.20.5
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Matt.4.10
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cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Isa.44.17

License audit

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Flags

lexically-disputed · cross-tradition-divergent